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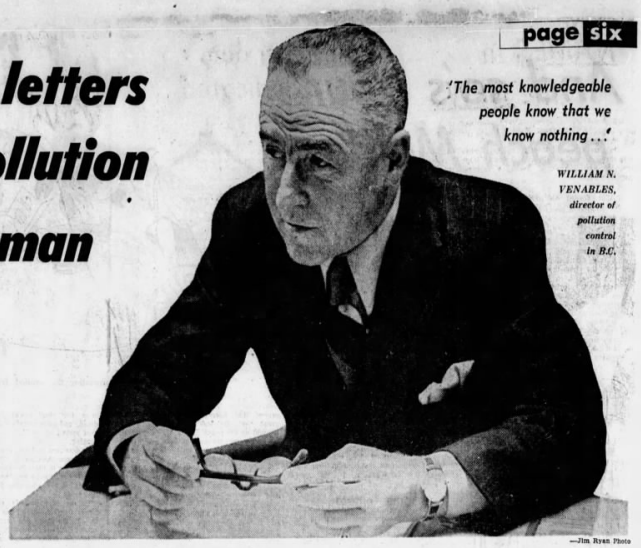
Your 15,500 letters protesting pollution deluged this man

By ROD MORGAN



'The most knowledgeable people know that we know nothing...'

WILLIAM N. VENABLES, director of pollution control in B.C.

—Jim Ryan Photo

VICTORIA—Several thousand letters have arrived at the pollution control board offices in the last two weeks from all kinds of industrial plants in British Columbia.

They contain technical data largely unintelligible to the non-scientist, sprinkled with such words as mercury, cyanide, arsenic and lead.

These thousands of letters are official registrations from industry of what exactly they are pouring onto the land and into the waters of this province.

Under B.C.'s revised Pollution Control Act, all discharges not at present permitted must be reported to the pollution control branch.

The branch has already called for extra staff to handle the registrations alone, and it may be years before the data volunteered by industry can be checked, and finally authorized, under a permit, or forbidden.

There will be more registrations at the same time next year, when discharges into the air must be reported.

But these official letters, demanded by law, are nothing compared with the average of 60 letters per day arriving at the pollution control branch's unobtrusive offices on a quiet street in Victoria — that's 300 per week, or more than 15,500 letters annually.

These are only from the people who take the trouble to sit down and write down their feelings. And there are more letters which go to the pollution control branch's parent department, water resources.

The letters are just one indication of the massive public concern which now centres on the equally massive subject of environmental collapse.

What is being done about pollution by the provincial government? And what is it doing to inform the people?

The main tool is the Pollution Control Act (1967). This is administered by the pollution control branch, under the direction of the pollution control board.

The board makes general policy decisions, and hears appeals.

The spade work is done by the branch.

The branch is composed of 45 people. Three years ago it was five. Most of their work is paper work, so forget that image of eggheads out taking samples of rivers and sniffing at the air.

What the branch basically has to do is prevent pollution, obviously enough. But what exactly is pollution?

According to the Pollution Control Act, which is the authority that is actually applied, "pollution means the introduction into a body of water, or storing upon, in, or under land, or discharging or emitting into the air such substances or contaminants of such character as to substantially alter or impair the usefulness of the land, water, or air."

The word *usefulness* may surprise you in this definition, but don't forget, people come under "Health," and motor vehicles come under "Motor Vehicles."

The basic idea is protection of resources — British Columbia's number one treasure trove.

So it narrows down a little.

The pollution the control branch is aiming at is whatever could make B.C.'s resources useless.

This means, mainly, discharges. Discharges require permits, by law, and the pollution control branch issues, and refuses, those permits.

And that is where the crunch comes.

More accurately, the crunch comes somewhere inside the head of one man entrusted with making the judgments on what are generally called "permits to pollute."

It falls to the lot of William N. Venables, B.Sc., M.A.Sc., P.Eng., director of pollution control, to decide whether, for example, muck dredged up from Burnaby Lake should be dumped into the Fraser River.

Or, more in tune with today's science fiction world, whether billion-dollar U.S. mining interests should pump fluorescent green stuff with pink blobs in it into the sea by the hundreds of thousands of gallons.

> *"The technological dream is becoming a nightmare and it is time to wake up or we may die in our sleep."*
>
> *—Gordon Rattray Taylor in The Doomsday Book 1970*

Quite a hot seat to sit in, you may think. Not surprisingly, Venables doesn't look at ease in it.

When this reporter arranged with Venables to meet at the branch offices in Victoria, Venables said his public relations officer would be there.

But one wondered how often the PRO's services were called upon, because Venables couldn't remember his name, which turned out to be Alan Jenkins.

Then Venables referred to the interview as another "training session."

Both Venables and Jenkins lit up smokes as the talking began. Venables looked spruce in a gold shirt, striped tie, matching handkerchief in breast pocket and what looked like a bespoke navy blue chalk-stripe suit.

He enjoys a fat, long cigar, and affects half-rim spectacles, which add the magisterial tone. He is 52 years old.

"I'm not a bureaucrat," he says. "I came in from business."

Venables went on, under questioning, to say that he came to British Columbia by choice to work in pollution control because he thought B.C. had the best control act.

"Whenever anything comes up, and my staff knows this, I always say refer to the act. I'm a civil servant working within the limitations of the act."

He explained —

- The history of pollution legislation (almost negligible before 1967, and nonexistent before 1957).
- The difference between a hearing and an enquiry: hearings listen to arguments on permit applications, enquiries seek information on broader issues.
- The divisions of the branch into six districts covering the province.

"We're still spread quite thin," he commented.

Asked about the recent news reports of Georgia Strait dogfish food products being found to have high mercury levels, Venables said "We are not so sure that mercury isn't something we can't ordinarily expect to find in nature."

He referred to the public's great "interest" in such cases, and concluded that new mercury detection techniques perfected in the last year could indicate minute amounts of the poisonous metal.

"So it's possible that we're finding what was already there."

"The most knowledgeable people know that we know nothing. We don't know where we've been, where we are, or where we're going until we start to monitor our environment. Until we know the facts, anyone can say anything."

Here he mentioned the large number of letters flowing into the pollution control branch "seeking assurance," and creating a "fantastic workload."

He did not specify what the workload was, since he would not say whether the letters are answered in any way or not.

"We do our best" was all he would offer.

But when Venables expanded on the letters, it became evident that, in his opinion, few of them deserved answers.

He said most of them were foolish questions. "For example, I have a letter asking why, in view of the fact people in India and China use human wastes as fertilizers on their fields, why we haven't approached the solution of shipping our wastes to these people to save them from starving.

"And that question didn't come from a child," he said.

Simple questions of fact are replied to with brochures, he said. He mentioned getting a "sharp letter from a well-educated person" protesting a duplicated form-letter.

At this point, a question about how pollution controls would be enforced and whether a new kind of police force would be needed sent both Venables and Jenkins off on a spate of governmental ramblings.

The "training session" began to grow obscure. "Utilizing all the expertise" and a "very determined effort to interrelate all these things" and "multi-agency consultation" seemed to be about getting things together, but didn't quite sound that way.

So, off the deep end, Mr. Venables, do you subscribe to the fast-spreading idea of some kind of environmental doomsday lying ahead? Possibly in the fairly near future?

"All the people saying this . . . There's no over-all assessment," Venables replied. "Before Christopher Columbus you could say the world was flat."

"You hear Lake Erie is dead, or dying. Is this opinion based on information?

"When you look into the facts you're often shocked. Doomsday? Like everyone who has spent time on this planet, you say things aren't as good as they were when you were a boy."

"You're calling on your memory. You must keep in mind what you're looking at — it is change. It can be misconstrued as deterioration."

Was Mr. Venables aware that his predecessor, C. J. Kenzie, who is private business, had been quoted saying something very similar in the Victoria papers the day before?

"Everybody realizes it," he said.

"You have to be dedicated in this field," Venables continued. "If you want to satisfy personal ambition, you do it outside government."

He said that in dealing with big companies and international industrial interests "we have to bring the moral element to bear."

"I have a leaning towards the missionary element. I came out of business with only one interest, to see pollution controlled. I felt I wanted to put something back into life, and the implement is the act —if we work outside it then it will never be tested.

"I say read the act, read the act, read the act — the staff knows this."

Later in the discussion, Venables said the world's greatest group (with regard to fighting pollution) is the Christian church.

"The type of situation we've got is so personal to people," he said at another point. "I think it's wrong to create fear."

But what if the reality is fearful?

"There must be public awareness."

How deep Venables' experience of a possible world environmental collapse is, and consequently how urgently he is "dedicated" to anti-pollution became even less clear when, unprompted by questioning, he went into how people "can condition themselves to anything."

In a series of apparently disconnected examples, Venables referred to "the English cleaning up London's air."

"All they did was abolish fireplaces — people had to spend money for alternative heating," he said.

With regard to sewage effluent, Venables recalled that 20 years ago a man had taken him to a wall dividing sewage from its effluent at a sewage plant.

"He dipped a cup in the effluent and drank it," he said.

Venables concluded his examples with the statement: "Top athletes of the world have come out of London and New York."

Later Venables repeated that he is an anti-pollutionist. He said for that reason SPEC (the Society for Pollution and Environmental Control) doesn't bug him.

"I have said that at public hearings the objectors and I are sitting on the same side of the table."

He said claims that objectors had been forbidden to speak at public hearings were unfair because unless an objector was properly registered as such before the meeting, he had no authority to hear him, according to the act.

No prescribed limit on industrial expansion for the province could be set, he said, because industrial techniques are always changing and developing.

He said pollution standards have to be viable (that is, applied to the region) rather than fixed at some absolute, because standards being low in some areas would swiftly ruin B.C.'s high standards.

The only real way to attack pollution, he said, is to bring it home as a moral responsibility to everyone, which requires a massive education program.

So there it was. Venables was starting at the top, referring to his interview as a training session. But it is questionable whether there is any need for a training program in view of more than 15,500 concerned letters that pour into the pollution control branch offices annually.

The director walks a razor's edge, as his training session showed, between the damnation of appearing to belittle the environmental situation, and the limbo of being a radical.

How long would a director who stated and applied his radicalism stay in office?

If he were fired, an apologist might take his place.

The only true measure of William Venables' professed dedication to anti-pollution is the stringency with which he applies B.C.'s only water, air and forest protection weapon, the Pollution Control Act.

But crucial decisions will go on being based on those mysteries at the heart of it all — science, technical know-how, the chemistry of poisons.

As the director of pollution control with those impressive letters behind his name, he tells us — "We don't know where we've been, where we are, or where we're going."

The thousands of registrations at present being analysed are at least a first step towards charting a position.

COMMENTARY BY SENATOR JOHN NICHOL

A monumental debate

When you think about it, it's so obvious. Canada needs a national monument! France has the Arc de Triomphe *and* the Eiffel Tower. The Americans have the Washington, Lincoln and Jefferson monuments, to say nothing of the Statue of Liberty and the horrible heads on Mount Rushmore. England is rotten with monuments. And here we are, the true north strong and free, without a decent place for the pigeons to perch.

It's true that we have quite a few statues. There's one of Mackenzie King on the lawn on Parliament Hill that looks like a stylized version of Chairman Mao before his swim in the Yangtze. He stands on the lawn, with other "figures" from Canadian history, watching the traffic go by on Wellington Street.

There is a statue of Sir Galahad right on the curb. He waits through eternity for the Metcalfe Street traffic signal signal to go green.

In Stanley Park there is a memorial to Warren Gamaliel Harding — perhaps the only one in existence.

The Peace Tower is nearly a monument, but it's part of the Parliament buildings, and thus doesn't really stand out on its own right.

The Centennial Flame was a good idea, but its design isn't particularly awe-inspiring. It is about three feet high and 12 feet in diameter, like a huge doggy bowl. Sometimes on a misty evening one gets the eerie feeling that perhaps, like King Kong, a monster spaniel will lift its great head over the East Block and come for a drink.

What we need is a great Monument Debate. The Flag Debate is far behind us — but what a wonderful time that was. Here was an issue that all Canadians could understand — in which we could are *participate*. No need to be an economist, chartered accountant, physics professor, or computer expert.

Blue bars? Red bars? One leaf? Three? Everyone was an expert. And while Parliament was distracted by these arguments, the nation boomed, and unemployment dropped to a ten-year low.

But the Monomument Debate would be even better. The Flag Debate dealt only with design and color. In a debate on a National Monument, these two problems would be only the beginning. Where would it be located? How big? What? Bronze? Stone? Wood? The arguments would be happily endless.

One preliminary suggestion calls for the construction of a huge marble arch on the lawns of Parliament Hill. Picture this in your mind's eye. The arch is 200 feet high, 150 feet long and 40 feet thick — a triumphal arch in every sense, like the Arc de Triomphe in Paris, only bigger and much uglier.

Beneath the arch is a bronze altar from which springs an eternal flame fired by natural gas. This is known as The Tomb of the Unknown Taxpayer.

Each year at midnight on April 30, just as the income tax returns are due, a solemn cavalcade of cabinet ministers and deputy ministers would "attend at" the monument and lay wreaths to the memory of the 30 million anonymous Canadians who make all idiocies possible!

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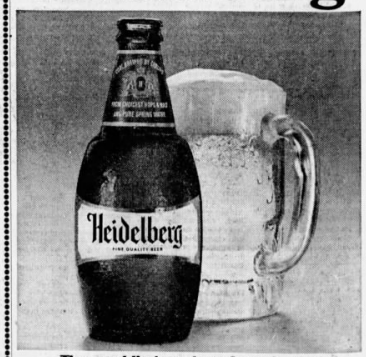

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